
*Phyllanthus amarus*

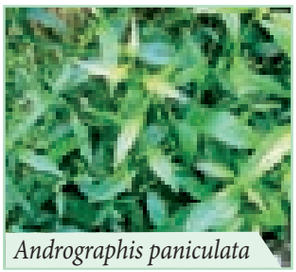

*Andrographis paniculata*

**Figure 10.19:** Medicinal Plants

effectively used to treat malaria and dengue.

## Psychoactive Drugs

In the above chapter you have learnt about plants that are used medicinally to treat various diseases. Phytochemicals / drugs from some of the plants alter an individual's perceptions of mind by producing hallucination are known as psychoactive drugs. These drugs are used in all ancient culture especially by Shamans and by traditional healers. Here we focus on two such plants namely Poppy and Marijuana.

### Opium poppy

Botanical name : *Papaver somniferum*

Family: Papaveraceae

**Origin and Area of cultivation:** *Opium poppy* is native to South Eastern Europe and Western Asia. Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh are the licenced states to cultivate opium poppy.

Opium is derived from the exudates of fruits of poppy plants. It was traditionally used to induce sleep and for relieving pain. Opium yields **Morphine**, a strong analgesic which is used in surgery. However, opium is an addiction forming drug.

### Cannabis / Marijuana

Botanical name : *Cannabis sativa*

Family: Cannabiaceae

**Origin and Area of Cultivation:** Marijuana is native to China. States such as Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Uttarkand, Uttarpradesh and Madhaya Pradesh have legally permitted to cultivate industrial hemp/Marijuana

The active principle in Marijuana is **trans-tetrahydrocanabinal** (THC). It possess a number of medicinal properties. It is an effective pain reliever and reduces hypertension. THC is used in treating **Glaucoma** a condition in which pressure develops in the eyes. THC is also used in reducing nausea of cancer patients undergoing radiation and chemotherapy. THC provides relief to bronchial disorders, especially asthma as it dilates bronchial vessels. Because of these medicinal properties, cultivation of cannabis is legalized in some countries. However, prolonged use causes addiction and has an effect on individual's health and society.

**Table 1: Other commo Medicinal plants**

| S. No | Common Name | Tamil Name | Botanical Name | Family | Plant part used | Medicinal Uses |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Holy basil | துளசி | *Ocimum sanctum* | Lamiaceae | Leaves and Roots | The leaves are stimulant, antiseptic, anti-hypertensive and anti-bacterial and expectorant used in bronchitis. Decoction of roots is given as a diaphoretic in malarial fevel. |
| 2 | Indian gooseberry | நெல்லி | *Phyllanthus emblica* | Phyllanthaceae | Fruit | It is a potent rejuvenator and immune modulator. It has a anti-ageing properties. It helps to promote longevity, enhance digestion, treat constipation and reduce fever and cough. |
| 3 | Indian Acalypha | குப்பைமேனி | *Acalypha indica* | Euphorbiaceae | Leaves | Used to cure skin diseases caused by ringworms. Powdered leaves are used to cure bedsores and infected wounds. |
| 4 | Vilvam | வில்வம் | *Aegle marmelos* | Rutaceae | Fruit | The unripe fruit is used to treat problems of stomach indigestion. It kills intestinal parasites. |
| 5 | Veldt grape | பிரண்டை | *Cissus quadrangularis* | Vitaceae | Stem and root | Paste obtained from the powdered stem and root of this plant is used in bone fractures. Whole plant is useful to treat asthma and stomach troubles. |



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